





A LASTING LEGACY
(Clockwise from far left) The East India House in Uttan, traditional earthenware at the Kaka Baptista East Indian Museum and Noren Gharshi serving a delicious spread

FOOD

East *by West*

There's a renewed interest in Mumbai's East Indian community, especially its cuisine

Heritage walks through Mumbai's East Indian precincts of Khotachiwadi and Mathar Pakhady, and villages like Ranwar, Sherly-Rajan, Chuim, Waroda and more in Bandra are becoming popular. Annual festivals in these areas are increasingly being attended by people from outside the fold, with Khotachiwadi Alive celebrating its fourth edition recently. Eminent designer James Ferreira (who welcomes guests into his 200-year-old East Indian bungalow via Airbnb) and other prominent East Indians are working to create more awareness about this unique community. Archaeologist and researcher Dr André Baptista, an East Indian and fourth-generation resident of Khotachiwadi, says, "The East Indians had ancestors who were the original residents of Mumbai. Even today, they may identify as Koli, Agri, Kunbi, etc., but the main thing linking them all is Roman Catholicism."

There is a rising interest in East Indian cuisine at every level too, be it patronising the many 'aunty kitchens' in Manori, Gorai, Uttan, etc., trying Chef Gresham Fernandes' bottle masala-laced delights at Salt Water Café, or signing up for fabulous boxes of East Indian delicacies that Chef Paul Kinny, Director of Culinary, St Regis Mumbai, had curated a while ago.

Chef and food stylist Michael Swamy, who authored the recipe book *The East Indian Kitchen* in 2011 (slated to have a new edition by the year-end), says, "Unlike Goan cuisine that uses fresh wet masalas, East Indian cuisine has similar dishes but uses dry masalas. Close to 30 herbs and spices go into the East Indian bottle masala. Some traditional dishes are disappearing because many East Indians have moved overseas and Gen X is not so involved. But a few rooted households, like in the villages of Bassein, still use recipes handed down over generations."

Norin Gharshi and son Maxson lay out an elaborate lunch at their home in Uttan village on the outskirts of Mumbai. There's *bombil* (Bombay duck fish) chutney, *kardi* (dried shrimp) chutney, chicken *moilee*, pork *vindaloo*, potato chops, plus melt-in-your-mouth *chitaps* and fluffy *fugiyas* to soak up the gravies rich in East Indian bottle masala.

"Nearly 30 herbs and spices go into the East Indian bottle masala," says chef Michael Swamy

The lunch with the Gharshis is an authentic home-cooked meal offered as a value-add by East India House, a beautiful boutique resort in Uttan. The property boasts an infinity pool and its own stylish restaurant has been created by architects with a passion for design and local culture. "The resort is a tribute to the small but vibrant East Indian community around us," says partner Rohan Salian. Instead of numbers, each room bears the name of an East Indian person, with his/her portrait crafted on an azulejo tile at the door.

A few kilometres from East India House is the Kaka Baptista East Indian Museum, named after the eminent East Indian lawyer and Mumbai's first mayor, who was a close confidant of Lokmanya Bal Gangadhar Tilak. It's rumoured he was the one who coined the phrase 'Swaraj is my birthright, and I shall have it' that Tilak made famous.

The museum showcases clothing, utensils, religious artefacts and books donated by elders. Alphi D'Souza, one of the three founder-trustees of the Mobai Gaothan Panchayat, says, "When we came together to form the organisation in 2010, our aim was to create something for posterity."

The museum receives about a hundred visitors a month, several of whom are not East Indian. They are guided through the exhibits by the charming caretaker Collette Kini and her young daughter Steffi. A Bible in Konkani-Marathi titled 'Christy Puran' is perhaps most symbolic of the community's syncretic nature, blending the best of Roman Catholicism and North Konkan culture. ■

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